

work. We'll never say "If I can do it, so can you" because we realize everyone's situation is different. We recognize that in many ways we live a privileged life, and some of the hard work that paid off for us five years ago isn't replicable now. So, we aim to share foundational principles that are eternally applicable to as many people in as many life situations as possible. While the principles are unchanging, they can be uniquely applied to any season throughout your life.

## How to Master the Skill of Spending Money

If you want to hone your spending skills, it helps to first have a framework for learning a skill in general. We use the Shuhari philosophy. Shuhari is a Japanese martial art concept that describes the stages of learning a skill to mastery, and it helps avoid overwhelm when starting something new.

*Shuhari* roughly translates to "follow the rules, break the rules, transcend the rules."

*Shu* means to follow a teacher fully without question. When you're first starting to learn something, whether it be a hobby, language, or spending, you choose one teacher and follow everything they say. There's a lot of conflicting advice in personal finance, and as a beginner you could pull your hair out trying to make sense of it all. So, following one teacher at first can make it easier to put things into practice.

*Ha* means to break away. Once you have an understanding of basic principles, then you start experimenting with breaking the "rules." If you study famous artists, you can usually see this visually over the body of their works. Once they get comfortable with their teacher's style, they start to innovate and develop their own style based on it. You can start to disagree with authors, influencers, and podcasters whose desires, lifestyle, and season are different from yours. Again, you'll never find a perfect teacher. No expert's life or choices are going to fully line up with yours, that's why it's good to have multiple teachers. Find a collective wisdom from a variety of experts who help you keep moving in the right direction.

*Ri* means to transcend. At this stage you've "mastered"—not perfected—your skill. You'll never be a perfect spender, or perfect at anything for that matter, but at this point you've earned the right to be confident and make your own rules. It's important to get to this stage but not to rush it. People